It is little wonder that the Chinese government was probably the first to understand the full importance of what was happening. In the nineteenth century, China was late to appreciate the potential of the Industrial Revolution and was slow to adopt inventions like railways and steamships. It consequently suffered what the Chinese call ‘the century of humiliations’. After having been the world’s greatest superpower for centuries, failing to adopt modern industrial technology brought China to its knees. It was repeatedly defeated in wars, partially conquered by foreigners and thoroughly exploited by the powers that did understand railways and steamships. The Chinese vowed never again to miss the train.

In 2017, China’s government released its ‘New Generation Artificial Intelligence Plan’, which announced that ‘by 2030, China’s AI theories, technologies, and application should achieve world-leading levels, making China the world’s primary AI innovation center’.[10] In the following years China poured enormous resources into AI so that by the early 2020s it was already leading the world in several AI-related fields and catching up with the United States in others.[11]

Of course, the Chinese government wasn’t the only one that woke up to the importance of AI. On 1 September 2017, President Putin of Russia declared, ‘Artificial intelligence is the future, not only for Russia, but for all humankind … Whoever becomes the leader in this sphere will become the ruler of the world.’ In January 2018, Prime Minister Modi of India concurred that ‘the one who control [*sic*] the data will control the world’.[12] In February 2019, President Trump signed an executive order on AI, saying that ‘the age of AI has arrived’ and that ‘continued American leadership in Artificial Intelligence is of paramount importance to maintaining the economic and national security of the United States’.[13] The United States at the time was already the leader in the AI race, thanks largely to the efforts of visionary private entrepreneurs. But what began as a commercial competition between corporations was turning into a match between governments, or perhaps more accurately, into a race between competing teams, each made of one government and several corporations. The prize for the winner? World domination.